



Afrikaans Language Monument

An iconic South African landmark that celebrates one of the world's youngest languages



The Afrikaans Language Monument was erected in 1975 to mark the 50th anniversary of Afrikaans as an official language of South Africa. Situated on Paarl Mountain, Western Cape, it was designed by architect Jan van Wijk, who sought to establish a link between the evolution of the language and the form of the monument. To this end, its tallest spire, 187 ft (57 m) high, indicates the growth of Afrikaans, while smaller, adjoining structures suggest the key influence of Africa and, by contrast, the declining influence of European languages on Afrikaans.

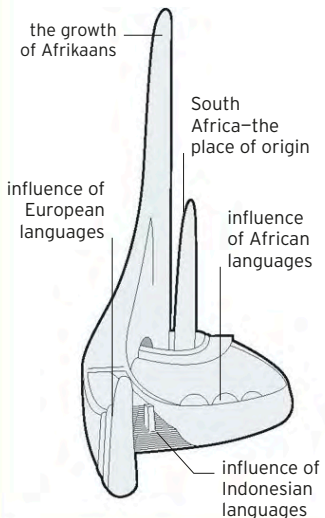
Cultural construction

Constructed over 2 years, the structure—also known as Taalmonument—symbolizes the convergence of nationhood, language, and landscape. It is made from Paarl granite, white sand, and cement, which has been hammered to evoke the texture of the surrounding rocks.

The monument initially attracted controversy as it was built during the apartheid era (1948–1994) and was perceived to privilege Afrikaans as South Africa's primary language, with English being considered less important and with no regard for indigenous local languages, which were not recognized in what was then "white" South Africa.

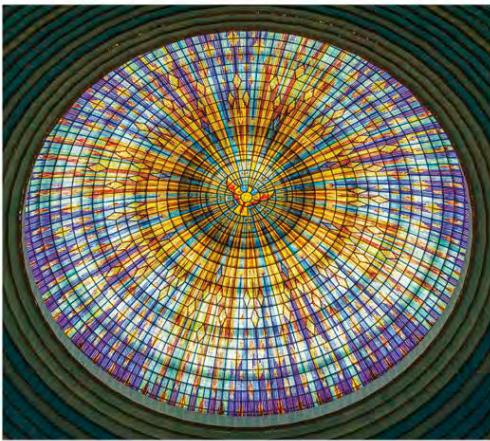
LAYOUT AND SYMBOLISM

The monument's main column represents Afrikaans as a developing language. A smaller column symbolizes South Africa. Three obelisks of varying height suggest the contribution of European languages in shaping Afrikaans, while different-sized domes indicate the role of Africa. Indonesian influences are shown by a wall on the stairway.



△ INSIDE THE BASILICA

Spectacular stained-glass windows and imposing columns are among the church's most distinctive features. Its pews, which can seat around 7,000 people, were made from West African Iroko wood, which turns from yellow to a rich copper color with age.



△ CENTER OF THE DOME

A dove with outstretched wings, measuring around 23 ft (7 m) in width, appears in the central position of the stained glass at the heart of the dome.

▽ BLENDING IN

The sculpture was designed to suggest a dialogue with nature. Its lines and curves replicate the peaks and dips of the landscape, and the material used in its construction helps it blend in with its rocky surroundings.

